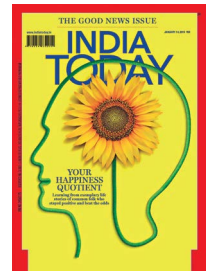
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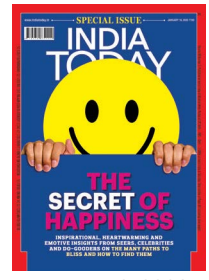
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Bad news usually goes viral, while good news tends to be buried in the welter of negative developments that are churned out with metronomic regularity. So, in 2016, we at INDIA TODAY decided to break the dominance of gloom by annually bringing out an entire issue devoted to heartwarming developments. This year, it segued neatly into our Republic Day special issue. We decided to give you a collage of positive and inspiring individuals and institutions that have spread good cheer by their actions. But what you will find in the following pages are not some islands of bliss unconnected to the outside reality, not exceptions that prove the rule. These stories mark out a salutary state that's getting generalised, in different ways and across different domains of Indian life.

All the areas we touch on have a 'spread effect'. To name a few, take gender equality at the workplace, or advancements in eco-friendly farming and food cultures, or the flow of technology from the top-end niche occupied by scientists to the teeming working classes in rural India, or the building of human capacity in sports, the arts, media and entertainment. They may be work in progress, but they hold a genuine promise of an exponential growth curve. Happiness as a process.



January 14, 2019



January 16, 2023

Take gender. When we think of the inequities faced by women, our minds reflexively pivot to the parts of society still sunk in conservative mores—especially in the hinterland. Look, instead, at corporate India and urban working spaces to find cussedly enduring layers of bias that inhibit the growth of women. Happily, this is beginning to change. We have an in-depth report of how many Indian companies are striving for diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI) at their workplaces. From hiring policies, to ceasing to treat maternity as a burden on the system or a point where women will exit, to creating leadership pipelines, these pioneers are dismantling restrictive structures and making India Inc more conducive for women and transgenders. Four out of the seven directors at Zomato are women. Deloitte, with an overall diversity rate of 38 per cent but with women at the top still lagging at 16 per cent, has put in place an incubation programme to "move the needle" there. Other companies like HCL Technologies and Axis Bank are systematically preparing women for board positions. "It is critical to view women through the lens of ambition and the skills they possess rather than stereotyping them based on their life stages," says Axis's DEI head Harish Iyer. Across NSE-listed companies in India, women now occupy 20 per cent of all board positions—up from 5 per cent a decade ago.

Then there are those who are innovating with "farm to fork", taking us towards a sustainable future of food. The idea here is to create thriving zones while ensuring our production and consumption cultures have a positive or at least only a neutral impact on the environment. Witness the 16-member women's self-help group started by Minati Sabat. It was the Centre's Millet Mission and the Odisha government's Mission Shakti that together brought out the entrepreneur in the 46-year-old former homemaker. Set up just a year ago, the Millet Shakti Outlet at Bhubaneswar's Kalinga Stadium sells 32 varieties of millets-based cooked and dry items and has an average monthly turnover of around Rs 5-6 lakh, making each of its members a neat Rs 15,000-20,000. That too while helping popularise native crops that will feed our future. A pursuit with similar objectives but a much wider footprint is helmed by Gujarat governor Acharya Devvrat. Jivamrut, a no-expense fertiliser that he developed out of cow excreta and earthworms, has been adopted on 752,000 acres across all terrains and weather conditions from Kutch to Navsari to Saurashtra. This natural farming ingredient is changing the lives of 900,000 farmers in the state.

The overlap between food and health is ticked in another way by Didi ki Rasoi, in Bihar, which provides livelihood to 1,700-plus women while serving healthy meals to over 18,500 patients across various hospitals in the state every month. A visit to one of their 117 kitchens, which together have notched up a Rs 57.4 crore turnover since the project was launched in 2018, will bring you a tangible sense of well-being: the aroma of grilled chicken, the whiff of mushroom and dal, the hum of happy industry among a dozen women chefs. Another remarkable initiative is the Kankaria Lake Food Hub of Ahmedabad, which has become a model to set up 100 such zones across India. Their USP is safe, unadulterated and hygienic street food. Here, you have India's universal fondness for chatpata savouries but cured of their usual health pitfalls. Kankaria's 60-odd trained street food vendors offer delicious proof: pao bhaji, ice cream, khichu, samosa, dhokla, pani puri, bhel puri and dabeli. The clientele runs to around 12 million people every year. With the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India investing in training food handlers, independent third-party audits and certification under the Eat Right India movement, imagine the scenario when this is scaled up a hundred-fold. It should rub off on the 2 million vendors who make up India's street food market.

Happiness is infectious. Read through this anthology of 20 such stories—from a 'mini Brazil' in a Madhya Pradesh village, to a start-up zone in Bihar's West Champaran where 59 migrant workers have become entrepreneurs, to a former national champion hitting bull's eye with an archery academy in Maharashtra's Satara, to a Chhattisgarh village of 4,000 where every household has a YouTuber. Their content, we assure you, is happy. Ironically, India is ranked 126th out of 146 nations in the World Happiness Report, 2023. But the sample survey itself is limited and its measurement of well-being completely subjective. Pain and misery are commodities where we suffer from no particular scarcity, but the mountain of good work being done quietly rarely gets reflected. It is a sampling of these that we have chosen to highlight. The world doesn't have instruments to quantify the special ways in which Indians can create joy even in adversity. In keeping with the occasion, we are calling it the 'Republic of Happiness'—with its preamble being written by a group of exemplars who by their actions have spread joy across the country.

(Aroon Purie)